

European Settlers

The first European settlers in North America, arriving in the early 17th century, tended to dismiss Native American medical practices as nothing more than primitive savagery. The settlers relied largely on imported herbal medicines, or on European plants hardy enough to grow in eastern North America.

As time went by, however, the settlers' increased contact with indigenous peoples in the frontier regions fostered a healthy respect for their healing skills. Sometimes settlers adopted not just the plants but the harvesting and therapeutic methods as well. Joseph Doddridge, in *Notes on the Settlement and Indian Wars* (1876), relates that butternut bark (*Juglans cinerea*, p. 224) was peeled downward if it was to be used as a purgative (acting "downward" by purging the bowels), and upward for use as an emetic (acting "upward" by provoking vomiting).

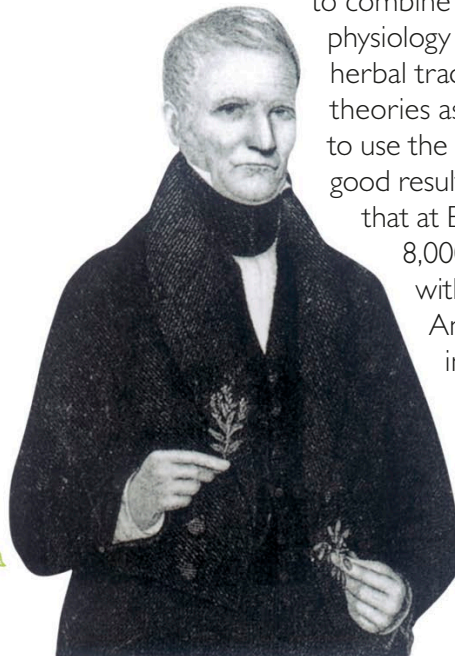
The types of healing regimens practiced by Native Americans eventually gained widespread popularity. Toward the end of the 18th century, Samuel Thomson (1769–1843) developed a simple therapeutic regimen based on Native American herbal practice. Thomson never acknowledged the debt, but it is clearly evident—from the use of emetics, purgatives, and stimulants, to the central role of sweating and vapor baths (based in part on Native American sweat lodges), to the deep knowledge of American medicinal plants. Thomson considered that "all disease is caused by cold" and his system worked well for those with a robust health struck down by infection or injury. The two main herbs in his system—cayenne, a stimulating herb, and lobelia, an emetic, relaxant, and stimulant—act to raise body temperature and dilate the blood vessels. Taking these plants helps to increase resistance to infection and speeds the healing of wounds.

Eclecticism & Its Influence

The fertile marriage between Native American and Western herbal medicine led to the establishment of more sophisticated herbal systems, such as Eclecticism, founded by Dr. Wooster Beech (1794–1868) in the 1830s. Beech studied both herbal and conventional medicine and tried

to combine the new scientific knowledge of physiology and pathology with the best of the herbal tradition. Beech rejected Thomson's theories as being overly simplistic, and aimed to use the lowest dosages possible to achieve good results. His approach was so successful that at Eclecticism's height in 1909, over 8,000 members were in practice, all with recognized medical qualifications.

Another significant medical movement, inspired by Thomson's regimen and influenced by the Eclectics, was Physiomedicalism. Using many herbs, these practitioners sought



Samuel Thomson, who inspired the 19th-century Physiomedicalists, advocated Native American remedies.

Witch hazel
(*Hamamelis virginiana*, p. 102) is excellent for skin conditions.

Witch hazel leaf

Witch hazel bark

Avocado leaf

Avocado bark

Avocado (*Persea americana*, p. 121) is an important medicinal plant in Guatemala, where all the parts are used as remedies.

Avocado fruit

Slippery elm
(*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145) is a Native American remedy for boils and wounds.

California poppy
(*Eschscholzia californica*, p. 207) is a gentle, effective sedative that is often used to encourage sleep.

Blue cohosh
(*Caulophyllum thalictroides*, p. 185) stimulates the uterus.